Praise of the Vajra of Mind

Cittavajrastava · Toh 1121 · Derge Tengyur
སེམས་ཀྱི་རྡོ་རྗེའི་བསྟོད་པ།

The Praise of the Vajra of Mind, in Sanskrit Cittavajrastava and in Tibetan Semkyi Dorjé Töpa, is a brief hymn of seven verses that its colophon attributes to the master Nāgārjuna. Opening with homage to Mañjuśrī, it praises one's own mind as the true object of devotion, teaching that awakening is the realization of mind, that the five destinies and all happiness and suffering are nothing apart from mind, and that saṃsāra is mere conceptual thought while freedom from conceptual thought is liberation. It closes by urging homage to the mind of awakening and careful guarding of the mind, from which buddhas arise. It is Toh 1121 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises, or stotra, among the hymns traditionally ascribed to Nāgārjuna.

In the language of India: cittavajrastavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Vajra of Mind

Homage to Mañjuśrī, the Youthful.

To one's own mind, which through mind itself
Has cleared away the net of mental factors,
And which dispels the delusion of mind,
I pay homage.

Sentient beings, with their various inclinations,
Focus on different deities;
Yet there is no deity to accomplish
Other than the precious mind set free.

Attaining the mind is awakening;
The mind is the five destinies;
As for the characteristics of happiness and suffering,
There is nothing at all apart from mind.

All the views of every being,
And even the slightest forms of meditation,
Were all taught to be the net of mind
By the Speaker of Reality (the Buddha).

The mind free of conceptual thought,
The mind swollen by conceptual thought:
Saṃsāra is nothing but conceptual thought,
And the absence of conceptual thought is liberation.

Therefore all, with effort,
Should pay homage to the mind of awakening;
Because one meditates on the vajra of mind,
It is called supreme awakening.

The mind that gives rise to the elements is bound by the body;
Without mind, the elements enter into bliss.
Therefore the mind should be guarded in every way:
From a mind of well-being, buddhas arise.

This completes the Praise of the Vajra of Mind, composed by the master Nāgārjuna.

Translator's Notes

• In the fourth verse, de nyid gsung bas is taken as "by the Speaker of Reality," an epithet of the Buddha; it could also be read as "this very point was taught by his speech." In the fifth verse, the sense of bsdos byas pa is uncertain and is rendered "swollen." In the seventh verse, khams bskyed sems may also be read as "the mind born of the elements."

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.